though, that it was all I wanted to do and I was lucky Dad was so willing to do it with me.

My dad, Ted, played himself for a local team called Kingfisher in the Forest and District League, and I would go along with my mum Sandra, my older sister Lynne and baby Joanne to watch him play. He was a center-forward; Mark Hughes, but rougher. He had trials for Leyton Orient and played semi-professional for a couple of years at Finchley Wingate. Dad was a good player, although he always used to get caught offside. It took me a long time to understand how that rule worked and I'm not sure Dad ever really got it sorted out. I loved watching him. I loved everything that went with the game, and I could tell how much playing meant to him as well. When he told me he was going to pack in playing regularly himself so he could concentrate on coaching me—I must have been eight or nine at the time—I knew exactly what that sacrifice meant even though he never talked about it in that way.

From the time I was seven, Dad was taking me to training with Kingfisher on midweek evenings down at a place called Wadham Lodge, just round the North Circular Road from us. I've got great memories of those nights, not just being with Dad and his mates, but of the ground itself. It was about ten minutes from the house in the car. We'd drive down this long street of terraced houses and pull in through a set of big, blue wooden gates, past the first parking lot and onto the second lot, which was right next to the training ground. The playing surface was orange-colored gravel and cinder, with proper goalposts and nets, and there was a little bar, the social club, that overlooked it. Beyond that field, there were three or four others, including the best one which was reserved for cup games and special occasions. It had a little wall all around it and two dugouts. It seemed like a massive stadium to me at the time. I dreamed about playing on that field one day.

Wadham Lodge wasn't very well looked after back then. Everywhere you turned was a mess, with mud on the floor, really dingy lighting and the water dribbling out of cold showers in the dressing rooms. Then there was the smell of the liniment that players used to rub on their legs. It would hit you as soon as you walked in. There were floodlights—just six lamps on top of poles—but at least once every session they'd go out and somebody would have to run in and put coins in a meter that was in a cupboard just inside the dressing room door.

As well as training with Kingfisher during the soccer season, we'd be back at Wadham Lodge in the summer vacations. Dad used to run, and also